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Written in May 2026 for Hinge's VP team as part of my candidacy for the Lead Product Manager, New User Experience role in New York.

Hi - I'm Aaron!



This is my wife Jenna,
and our 7-month-old
baby girl Joia.

I owe Hinge *a lot*.

Jenna and I met at work, but I used Hinge religiously in the years before her.

It was the only dating app I trusted to take seriously.

The combination of effort it asked for and the intentional dater it attracted was the rare consumer product that made me a better version of myself.

It was my growth catalyst.

By the time I met Jenna, I grew into the man who could keep her and love her the way she deserved to be loved.

I owe Hinge a great deal, as it was the catalyst for much of my personal growth and transformation.

The product
experience I'd
bring to Hinge



My product experience has been built across world-class brands and complex customer problems

KraftHeinz

Disney

NBA

Curology

Cloudflare

Shutterfly

CADRE

CIBC

lululemon

Coca-Cola

Capital

Johnson

mastercard

ARC'TERYX

CANADIAN
TIRE

HubSpot

Delivered through two agency roles over 14 years.

APPLY
DIGITAL

Director, Product Strategy & Transformation at Apply Digital, a high-growth product shop based out of Canada

SIMON
KUCHER

Head of Customer Experience for North America at Simon-Kucher, the #1 revenue growth consultancy in Europe

Who I am as a product leader

I've spent a decade learning what makes great product work - how to interpret behavior, build trust, create momentum, and turn messy problems into products people actually use.

I ship products that move the needle.

I take messy, undefined problems and turn them into experiences real users love, from first concept through launch, iteration, and scale

I've done for some of the world's best brands, and I own the work end-to-end.

I operate where art and science intersect.

I have the rigor of a data scientist and the eye of a designer.

I study what drives people to act, trust, and return, and I obsess over the craft that makes them want to.

I turn ambiguity into roadmaps.

I take vague leadership asks ("make onboarding better") and turn them into a clear sequence of bets with theses, tradeoffs, and success metrics.

I unify teams around a shared mission.

I work across the teams that build and grow the product - design, data, engineering, marketing, etc. - making sure we're all solving the same problem.

When alignment slips, I'm the one who pulls it back.

I connect every decision to value.

A decade at Simon-Kucher trained me to pressure-test every idea through who it's for, what it's worth, and why they'd choose it over others.

I build the business case alongside the product, so efforts tie back to outcomes.

I run teams that learn and win faster.

I break big bets into small, sharp tests designed to actually resolve a question.

I measure progress by hypotheses answered and learnings banked, not features shipped.

Two places to bet the future on

With the way the world is moving, Hinge is in an incredible position - and I want to be part of the growth, impact, and meaning that comes with helping a company like this at a moment like this.

Betting on AI

AI will reshape the next decade of value creation across the stack: models, infrastructure, applications, and the customer experiences built on top of them.

The biggest opportunities will sit with companies that can turn intelligence into products that learn faster, personalize better, and adapt in real time.

VS.

Betting on Love

As AI accelerates and the world becomes more uncertain, human connection becomes one of the clearest sources of stability and hope.

Hinge is one of the few companies using technology in service of that deeply human need - helping people move from uncertainty and distance toward real connection.

A look into Hinge's
current new user
experience.



The current new user experience consists of 6 phases

Phase 1: Identity

✓ Phone number and verification code

✓ Privacy agreement

✓ First and last name

✓ E-mail and verification code

✓ Birthday

✓ Location

✓ Profile preview

Preliminary thoughts

This phase works well and should stay quick. The main opportunity here is to make each step feel like it protects the experience, not just collects information.

A simple upfront trust screen could help frame these asks within Hinge's "3 promises" or "3 priorities":

- **Real People First:** explain verification stops bots
- **Relevant Nearby Matches:** explain location is necessary to show matches they can actually meet
- **You Stay In Control:** explain personal info improves the experience, but is not exposed publicly.

Email verification may be worth eliminating, as phone already carries most trust and anti-fraud burden.

The current new user experience consists of 6 phases

Phase 2: Facts & Preferences

- | | |
|----------------------|-------------------------|
| ✓ Gender | ✓ Education and job |
| ✓ Pronouns | ✓ Home town |
| ✓ Height | ✓ Children |
| ✓ Ethnicity | ✓ Religion and politics |
| ✓ Sexual orientation | ✓ Alcohol and drugs |
| ✓ Gender preference | ✓ Privacy acceptance |
| ✓ Connection type | ✓ Profile preview |

Preliminary thoughts

This phase is the biggest strategic tradeoff: speed vs. signal quality.

One path is to **shorten the flow**, collect only the highest-signal basics upfront, and use the promise of better recommendations / more visibility to motivate completion later.

The other path is to use this moment to **collect richer context** - voice, relationship style, conflict/stress patterns, love language, weekend habits - so the first recommendations feel more human and less generic.

I'd test both in pilot cohorts. The read should be whether richer upfront signal improves relevance and Day 1 retention enough to justify the added friction. The key is to avoid a middle path that is both long and shallow.

The current new user experience consists of 6 phases

Phase 3: Visuals

✓ Photo uploads

✓ Prompts

✓ Voice

Phase 4: Verification

✓ Biometric face scan

Preliminary thoughts

I'd want to see drop-off for photos and biometrics.

If there's drop-off at **biometrics**, it could be due to scan failure, unclear instructions, poor lighting, or no graceful recovery - not just reluctance. This is both a trust moment and a technical failure-risk moment.

The **6-photo requirement** creates real friction. We could make it easier with clearer guidance: 3 now and 3 later, camera roll suggestions, photo-quality tips, or examples of what each photo should do: face, full-body, social, hobby, candid, personality.

This is also a natural place to test offers later - local photographers, styling, barbers - but it should feel like helping users show up well, not monetizing insecurity.

The current new user experience consists of 6 phases

Phase 5: Paywall

- ✓ Paywall prompt
- ✓ Profile preview

Phase 6: Feed

- ✓ UI walkthrough
- ✓ Feed and text overlays

Preliminary thoughts

Phase 5 is sensitive as monetization appears before users have experienced value. The two-tier structure is hard to parse quickly, and there's an opportunity to make clearer what each tier does and how it improves visibility, control, or outcomes. Some frustrated users already believe Hinge withholds success unless they pay, so **clarity here can build trust.**

One test: automatically give new users a short trial of the highest tier, shifting the paywall from “pay before you know” to “keep what already helped.”

But the bigger risk begins in Phase 6. Once users reach the feed, they are judging whether Hinge actually works. The first 72 hours need to prove: **(1) these are real people, (2) I'm not invisible, and (3) this app isn't playing games with me.**

The funnel

Phase 1: **Identity**

Phase 2: **Facts & Preferences**

Phase 3: **Visuals**

Phase 4: **Verification**

Phase 5: **Paywall**

Phase 6: **Feed**

Phase 1 to 5 are recoverable.

Without seeing the data, I'd expect Phases 1 to 5 to create gradual drop-off: users get interrupted, run into friction, or decide they don't have the time or confidence to finish in that moment.

But most of that drop-off is likely recoverable. These users may still believe Hinge can work - they just haven't completed the setup yet.

The priority across Phases 1 to 5 is to reduce avoidable friction while making every required step feel purposeful: trust, relevance, profile quality, and control.

Phase 6 is the real risk.

If expectations are not met, hesitations are not addressed, or users do not experience clear value in the first 72 hours, the risk is not temporary drop-off - it's **permanent attrition**.

Phase 6

The 3 success factors to get right in the first 72 hours of feed usage

Prove *“These are real people.”*

“I’ve been on Hinge for a month and I personally think that 80% of the profiles are fake. Something is off.”



In dating, “real” doesn’t just mean identity verification - it also means recency, responsiveness, and evidence that this person is actually participating.

Best practice example and potential application for Hinge

- Hinge can learn from X/Twitter’s account context, BeReal’s recency, and LinkedIn’s social grounding. X shows ‘about this account’ data that transformed transparency and trust. BeReal shows that recent, low-polish moments feel harder to fake. LinkedIn shows that people feel more real when they are anchored in a broader life context.
- Hinge could test an Authenticity Context Layer on early profiles: “Verified with selfie check · Aug 2026,” “Active today,” “Joined Hinge in 2024,” “Profile updated this month,” or “Recent Moment · added 3 days ago.” The goal is not to expose private details - it is to make the first feed feel alive, current, and trustworthy.

Phase 6

The 3 success factors to get right in the first 72 hours of feed usage

Prove *“I’m not invisible.”*

“I don’t know how other men do on Hinge, but my profile feels basically invisible.”



The first 72 hours are emotionally dangerous because silence feels like rejection, even when the system is still learning. Users need evidence that their profile is live and circulated.

Best practice example and potential application for Hinge

- TikTok gives new creators an initial test audience so they do not feel like they are posting into the void. Uber turns waiting into visible progress: searching, matching, assigned, arriving. LinkedIn shows profile views and search appearances so users know they are being seen even before someone messages them.
- Hinge could test a Proof of Life System: a 24-48 hour New User Launch Window where profiles are circulated to a controlled pool of active, compatible users, paired with a Profile Activity Pulse: “Your profile is live,” “We’re introducing you to nearby daters,” “People are seeing your profile.” The product should not promise matches - it should prove the system is alive.

Phase 6

The 3 success factors to get right in the first 72 hours of feed usage

Prove *“This app isn’t playing games with me.”*

“I bought a week of HingeX and there was a drop off half way through it. So, you’re not safe from being throttled even if you pay.”



Dating apps create suspicion when users don’t understand the rules. If premium is opaque, users assume the worst - that they’re being hidden, throttled, manipulated, or forced to pay to be seen.

Best practice example and potential application for Hinge

- Instagram is a strong analogy here. Adam Mosseri has made Instagram’s ranking systems more legible by consistently, publicly explaining how the algorithm works and what signals affect distribution. Amazon explains recommendations with labels like “Because you viewed...” or “Recommended for you.”
- Hinge could build a System Transparency Layer: “How Hinge learns your type,” “Why we’re showing you this person,” “What Hinge+ does and doesn’t do,” and “How your actions improve recommendations.” Before the paywall, Hinge could explicitly say: “Hinge+ gives you more control. It does not hide your profile if you don’t pay. It does not guarantee matches. A strong profile and thoughtful likes still matter most.”

Discussing a major
focus area: the cold-
start problem.



While users may not explicitly ask for personalization or vocalize it as a pain point, the lack of it is felt in several ways

“I don’t want to click ‘like’ on any of the people I’m seeing”

- If the profiles that Hinge surfaces for a user feel consistently irrelevant, risk grows for them thinking “this app isn’t for me.”

“The people who click ‘like’ on me are not at all my type”

- Personalization is not just about who the user sees - it is also about who sees them. If inbound likes come from the wrong people, the user feels visible but not correctly understood.

“My matches don’t turn into good conversations or dates”

- Personalization has to optimize beyond attraction. The real goal is matching with enough shared intent and chemistry to create momentum toward an actual date.

The cold-start problem: when a personalization product meets a user it knows nothing about yet.

Every personalized consumer product - Netflix, Spotify, Amazon, YouTube, Hinge - depends on a recommendation system.

NETFLIX



- Recommendation systems learn by watching behavior: who users like, skip, pause on, and engage with.
- Cold-start is the gap between when a user joins and when the system has enough signal to personalize well. **In that gap, the product is effectively guessing based on limited inputs.**
- For some products, that's a temporary inconvenience - but for Hinge, it's a critical moment as the first 72 hours of usage shapes whether a user feels that the app 'gets' them or doesn't, risking their permanent attrition.

Dating apps have the hardest version of this problem

At Hinge, both cold-start problems happen simultaneously every day.

User cold-start: A new person joins. Hinge has limited signal on their taste, intent, lifestyle, communication style, and actual dating behavior. Who should we show them?

+

Marketplace cold-start: That same new person also becomes part of the dating pool. Hinge has limited signal on who might find them attractive, respond to them, or want to meet them. Who should we show them to?

Overcoming the cold-start problem means doubling down on 3 distinct 'jobs' that Hinge has to focus on excelling in

Build a stronger first read

In the beginning, Hinge barely knows the user. Better intake gives the app a stronger first guess: who they're drawn to, what they're looking for, what they won't compromise on, and where they might be open.

Correct the model in real time

People don't always know how to describe their type. Early actions - who they skip, pause on, like, or message - help Hinge learn what they actually respond to and fix the first guess faster.

Show the app is getting smarter

Users will give Hinge more chances if they can feel the app getting smarter. Showing that their answers and actions are shaping the next recommendations keeps them engaged, which gives Hinge more signal to learn from.

Early ideation

Build a stronger first read

Correct the model in real time

Show the app is getting smarter

	Consideration	Why it matters
1A. Taste calibration	Use lightweight exercises that reveal who the user is actually drawn to: “Which of these 3 profiles feels most like your type?” “Pick the date you’d actually be excited for.” “Which prompt answer would make you want to reply?”	Users are often bad at describing their type abstractly. Showing, choosing, and reacting creates better signal than asking them to self-report.
1B. Flexibility detection	Gently test which preferences are real dealbreakers versus defaults: “You said 6’0+ - would 5’10 matter if everything else clicked?” “You prefer nearby - would you widen distance for someone highly aligned?”	Many users over-filter early. Hinge can expand the recommendation pool without making users feel like it is ignoring their preferences.
1C. Intent and energy read	Ask questions that reveal dating mode, not just dating goals: “Are you trying to meet someone soon or browse slowly?” “Do you want playful banter, serious compatibility, or low-pressure conversation?”	“Looking for long-term” is too broad. Hinge needs to understand how the user wants dating to feel right now.

Early ideation

Build a stronger first read

Correct the model in real time

Show the app is getting smarter

	Consideration	Why it matters
2A. Skip / like pattern analysis	Look for clusters in who users consistently skip, pause on, expand, like, or return to. Detect whether the issue is attraction, profile quality, intent mismatch, distance, lifestyle, or prompt style.	Not all skips mean the same thing. The product needs to understand the pattern behind rejection, not just count the action.
2B. Stated vs. revealed preference gaps	Compare what users said in intake against what they actually engage with. For example: they say they want “ambitious professionals,” but pause on creative, outdoorsy profiles.	The most useful personalization often comes from the gap between what people think they want and what they actually respond to.
2C. Conversation quality signals	Track not just matches, but whether users actually message, reply, sustain conversation, exchange depth, or drop off. Use this to learn who creates momentum, not just who earns a like.	Likes are weak signals. Conversation momentum is much closer to real dating value. Hinge should optimize toward people users actually want to engage with.

Early ideation

Build a stronger first read

Correct the model in real time

Show the app is getting smarter

	Consideration	Why it matters
3A. Recommendation rationale	Add subtle “why this person” moments: “Shown because you said you value intentionality,” “Similar to profiles you spent more time on,” “Expands slightly beyond your filters.”	Early recommendations feel less random when users understand why they are seeing someone. This builds trust even before the model is perfect.
3B. Visible preference evolution	Show a lightweight evolving readout: “We’re learning you seem more open on distance than age,” “You respond more to thoughtful prompts than travel photos.”	Users need evidence that the system is learning from them. This makes personalization feel active, not hidden.
3C. Adaptive check-ins	Use small calibration moments after early sessions: “Were these closer?” “Want more like this or different?” “Should we loosen this filter or stay strict?”	The first 72 hours should feel like a feedback loop. Hinge asks, adapts, checks, and improves instead of dumping users into a static feed.

My first 90 days as
Lead Product Manager,
New Customer Experience.

In the first 90 days, I wouldn't rush to prove I have the answer.

I'd focus on earning enough context to make the right call, and enough trust to bring people with me.



New leadership that arrives with answers loses trust fast.



New leadership that arrives with sharp questions, demonstrated rigor, and visible respect for what's already been built earns the right to ship hard in quarter two.

So the plan below is deliberate about sequencing: listen and audit first, hypothesize and align second, ship a focused first test third.

Days 1 to 30:

Listen, Audit, Calibrate

Aim by day 30 is that I can describe Hinge's funnel by segment, name the three biggest gaps between research and shipped product, and articulate why I think the two priority bets in the role description are the right ones or what I'd reframe.

Read everything that hasn't shipped.

Hinge Labs has certainly produced more research than has been productized. The fastest wins in seat are usually buried in this gap. I'd spend the first two weeks living in the Labs backlog before forming any strong opinion of my own.

Map the funnel by segment.

Drop-off curve from sign-up → first like → first match → first message → first date, mapped against MAD. Cut by the relevant personas. The shape of that curve is what tells me which bet to ship first.

Run my own pulse research.

I have a personal audience of 50K+ daters and am able to run qualitative research quickly. In week three, I'd run a study asking key personas about the current Hinge UX. I'd bring these findings to SOTUB to ground the team's hypotheses in VoC.

Pressure-test the priorities.

The job description names two priority bets - cold-start relevance and journey-feels-rewarding. In week three, I'll suggest other frames: is there a 3rd or 4th question we're not asking? Not to override, but to surface what we'd be choosing not to do.

Sit with cross- functional partners.

One scheduled 1:1 with each lead across engineering, design, data, marketing, etc., in the first three weeks. The goal is understanding the constraints I'm not yet seeing - what's been tried, what failed, what's blocked, what's in flight.

Attend Wrap and SOTUB live.

Hinge describes both as load-bearing cultural pillars. I want to see how they actually run before I propose anything. By day 30, I want to have observed at least one full Wrap and one full SOTUB cycle as a listener.

Days 31 to 60:

Hypothesize, Align, Sequence

Aim by day 60 is that the team has aligned on a refined version of the bets, the metric tree is locked, the kill criteria are written, and the cross-functional spec for the first test is ready.

Turn findings into refined hypotheses.

What I learned is the input to a refined set of hypotheses. The job description specifically calls out hypothesis-driven experimentation; this is where that work happens - not before.

Lock the metric tree.

MAD as the primary, with the right intermediate metrics for each bet (first-rec like-rate, Day-0→Day-1 return, prompt-write completion rate, like-to-match conversion). Without a tree, teams measure their own thing & nothing compounds.

Write kill criteria for every proposed bet.

"We will stop this if X happens by Y date." This protects the team's ability to redirect investment fast when reality disagrees with the hypothesis. The IKEA effect is real in product orgs, and pre-committed kill criteria is what beats it.

Build the cross-functional plan.

By day 60 I want the spec for the first test fully written, the dependencies named across all teams, the timelines committed, and the team aligned.

Coach upward and outward.

I start modeling the operating cadence I want the broader PM org to inherit - structured discovery, hypothesis-led decision-making, kill criteria written before code. I'd use the second 30 days to set the tone, not the third.

Pre-mortem the first test before launch.

Run a pre-mortem for Bet 1 with the cross-functional team: imagine the test failed, what's the likely reason? This surfaces risks missed and gets the team aligned on what learning (not just winning) would look like.

Days 61 to 90:

First Test in Market

Aim by day 90 is that Bet 1 is live in a single test market, the team is reading instrumented data weekly, and Bet 2's data path is instrumented in shadow mode behind it.

Ship Bet 1 in a single test market.

Signal capture, one metro, matched control cohort, six-week read window. First-rec like-rate as an early indicator; MAD lift as the gate metric at 90 days. Intentionally narrow to get a clean read on one metric in one market with high confidence.

Prepare Bet 2 in shadow mode.

While the first experiment runs, instrument the next intervention in the background to understand marketplace impact and risk without contaminating the live test.

Establish the weekly reading rhythm.

Each week, bring the team together around a short written update: what moved, what didn't, and what we're doing next. The goal is to build a simple habit of learning and deciding together - not another meeting for slides.

Run a parallel qualitative read.

While the test runs, I'd speak with a small group of users each week to understand the "why" behind the data. The metrics tell us what moved; the conversations tell us what it actually felt like.

Read out at Wrap by Day 90.

By the end of the first 90 days, I'd share what we learned - what worked, what didn't, and what we're changing - in the forum where the company already discusses the work.

Set the cadence for everything to come.

By Day 90, the team should have more than a live test - it should have a clear cadence for weekly reads, cross-functional decisions, leadership updates, and roadmap sequencing tied to MAD.



Thank you for your
thoughtful consideration.

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